Frankly, I was not surprised with Azam Khan's behaviour. I had a run-in with Khan first in 2006 when we had done an exposé on his alleged land-grabbing in his bastion of Rampur. *'Main aapko jail mein daaloonga'* (I'll put you in jail), he had threatened then. A year later, as UP Speaker, he wanted me to appear before the state assembly for doing a sting operation that showed UP's politicians ready to trade in drugs for cash. He could speak flowery Urdu but could also be abusive. He represented that breed of dangerous politicians who saw themselves in pure religious terms, a politician who was a 'defender of the faith'.

Khan's anti-Modi rhetoric was predictable. The Congress, by contrast, seemed rather confused. When Modi's ascent first began in 2013, some Congressmen were unwilling to see him as an equal to their leadership. 'He is only another chief minister—why give him so much importance,' was the official party line. Others, though, could not stop taking him on. Kapil Sibal challenged Modi to a face-to-face debate. Salman Khurshid called him a 'frog', Jairam Ramesh referred to him as a fascist and Bhasmasur (a mythological character who had destroyed his creator).

That muddled approach seemed to influence Rahul too. He had avoided direct references to Modi in many of his public interactions. But in election season, he suddenly stepped up the heat. Modi was now Hitler, and worse. I attended a Rahul rally in Ghaziabad where he lashed out at his BJP rival. The Congress candidate here was the charismatic actor-politician Raj Babbar. If, at Modi's Meerut rally, the crowd had a desi rock concert feel to it, here there seemed to be an almost surreal silence. The noisy excitement, such an integral part of a festive occasion like an Indian election, was missing. It was almost as if the audience couldn't relate to what the leader was saying.

Rahul spoke of Modi's 'toffee model' of development. He claimed that the BJP leader had sold valuable land at just Re 1 to the Adanis, while farmers and the poor were neglected. 'Where once there was a partnership between Vajpayee and Advani, now Modi and Adani are business partners,' was Rahul's charge. There were a few, almost forced, handclaps.